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FUNDRAISING



**Fundamental Research
Labs nabs \$30M+ to
build AI agents across
verticals**



Applied AI research company [Fundamental Research Labs](#) (formerly known as Altera) announced today that it has raised \$33 million in Series A funding led by Prosus with participation from Stripe co-founder and CEO Patrick Collison.

The company has a curious structure, as it is working on multiple AI applications in different fields. When it raised its seed funding, Fundamental Research Labs was developing bots that could play Minecraft with you.

Today, the company has a games team, a prosumer team building apps, a core research team, and a platform team. The startup's founder, Dr. Robert Yang, a former faculty member at MIT, says that Fundamental Research Labs wants to be a "historical" company without adhering to a typical startup structure.

Yang said that the company is already charging users for this agent after a seven-day trial and bringing in revenue.

Among the products Fundamental Research Labs offers is a general-purpose consumer assistant called [Fairies](#). This app allows you to chat with an AI bot, connect applications, and ask questions across the knowledge bases of those applications, then ask it to schedule appointments for you on your calendar. The app can schedule workflows for you to repeatedly execute some tasks. Yang said

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that this app allows the startup's engineers to test out various capabilities of models and platform tech it is developing.

The company also offers a spreadsheet-based agent called [Shortcut](#), which has been used by analysts for creating different financial models and performing analysis over them. The startup said that this agent works like a junior analyst and can do work autonomously. The company has made it look like Excel and has tried to retain a lot of functionality for power users.

"We've seen many early-stage startups, but what stood out here is a small, highly mission-driven team focused on digital humans with actual use cases. Their recent launches, like Fairies and Shortcut, aren't just demos; they're already demonstrating how AI can augment the human workforce in meaningful ways," Sandeep Bakshi, an investment partner at Prosus, told TechCrunch over email.

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“What stood out with Fundamental Research Labs is not just the ambition of the vision, but again the caliber of the team driving it,” he added. “Their ability to attract some of the brightest minds in the world, and turn that talent into real-world products, makes this a uniquely compelling venture opportunity for us.”

The company raised [\\$9 million in a seed round last year](#), which was co-led by First Spark Ventures and Patron, with participation from a16z Speedrun and Eric Schmidt. The startup has raised over \$40 million in funding to date.



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Yang said the company is open to trying out various application models and eventually wants to build robots as well.

“We are working on productivity (apps) now because that is where the most value is created. You can make a lot of money doing this and build your team and tech. Eventually, we want to solve physical problems and move towards working on embodiment,” Yang said.

Correction: The funding round was \$33 million, not \$30 million; the story was updated with the accurate amount.

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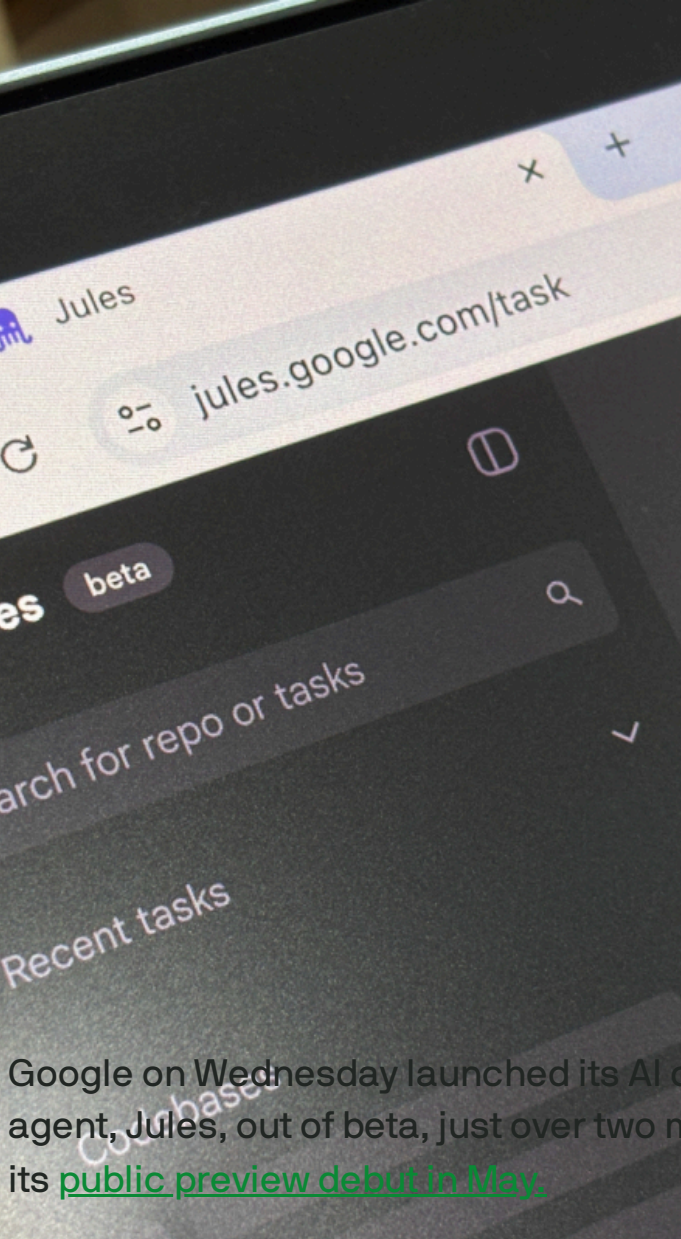
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Ivan covers global consumer tech developments at TechCrunch. He is based out of India and has previously...

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Google's AI coding agent Jules is now out of beta

Jagmeet Singh — 9:00 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

Google on Wednesday launched its AI coding agent, Jules, out of beta, just over two months after its [public preview debut in May](#).

Powered by Gemini 2.5 Pro, Jules is an asynchronous, agent-based coding tool that integrates with GitHub, clones codebases into Google Cloud virtual machines, and uses AI to fix or update code while developers focus on other tasks.

Google [initially announced](#) Jules as a Google Labs project in December and made it [available to beta testers](#) through a public preview at its I/O developer conference.

Kathy Korevec, director of product at Google Labs, told TechCrunch that the tool's improved stability drove the decision to take it out of beta after receiving hundreds of UI and quality updates during its beta phase.

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“The trajectory of where we’re going gives us a lot of confidence that Jules is around and going to be around for the long haul,” she said.

With the wider rollout, Google introduced structured pricing tiers for Jules, starting with an “introductory access” free plan capped at 15 individual daily tasks and three concurrent ones, down from the 60-task limit during beta. Jules’ paid tiers are part of the Google AI Pro and Ultra plans, which are priced at \$19.99 and \$124.99 a month, and offer subscribers 5x and 20x higher limits, respectively.

Korevec noted that Jules’ packaging and pricing are based on “real usage” insights gathered over the past couple of months.

“The 60-task cap helped us study how developers

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Korevec said.

During the beta, Google said that thousands of developers tackled tens of thousands of tasks, resulting in over 140,000 code improvements shared publicly. Initial feedback led the Google Labs team to add new capabilities, including reusing previous setups for faster task execution,

integrating with GitHub issues, and supporting multimodal input.

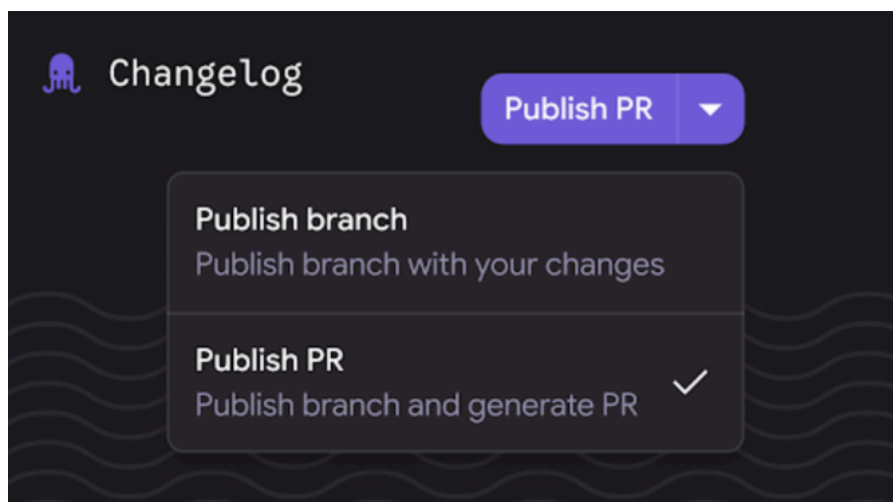


IMAGE CREDITS: JULES / X

The two primary users of Jules so far are the AI enthusiasts and professional developers, Korevec said.

By running asynchronously in a virtual machine, Jules stands apart from top AI coding tools like Cursor, Windsurf, and Lovable, which all work synchronously and require users to watch the output after each prompt.

“Jules operates like an extra set of hands ... you can basically kick off tasks to it, and then you could close your computer and walk away from it if you want and then come back hours later. Jules would have those tasks done for you, versus if you were doing that with a local agent or using a synchronous agent, you would be bound to that session,” Korevec explained.

This week, Jules received a deeper integration with GitHub to [open pull requests automatically](#) — just like it could open branches — and a feature called [Environment Snapshots](#) to save dependencies and install scripts as a snapshot for faster, more consistent task execution.

From vibe coding to mobile use, beta trials informed Jules' development

Since entering public beta, Jules has logged 2.28 million visits worldwide, 45% of them from mobile devices, per data from market intelligence provider [SimilarWeb](#), reviewed by TechCrunch. India was the top market for traffic, followed by the U.S. and Vietnam.

Google did not share specifics on Jules' user base and its top geographies.

Korevec told TechCrunch that during the beta, the team observed that many people used Jules from traditional vibe-coding tools to either fix bugs that might have been implemented or extend the vibe-coded project to make it more production-ready.

Originally, Jules required users to have an existing codebase. But Google soon realized many potential users — like those trying other AI tools — might want to explore it without one. Korevec said the company quickly enabled Jules to work even with an empty repository. That helped increase its scope and usage.

Google Labs' team also noticed an increasing number of users accessing Jules through their mobile devices. Although the tool does not have a dedicated mobile app, Korevec said users were accessing it through its web app.

“Since it’s a big use case that we’re seeing emerging, we’re absolutely exploring what the features are that people need on mobile a lot more,” she noted.

Alongside beta testers, Korevec stated that Google already uses Jules to help develop some projects

internally, and there is now a “big push” to use the tool on “a lot more projects” at the company.

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Jagmeet Singh

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Jagmeet covers startups, tech policy-related updates, and all other major tech-centric developments from India for...

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AI



AI agents aren't the 'new Google,' says Airbnb CEO

Sarah Perez — 8:37 AM PDT · August 7, 2025

After a second-quarter earnings [beat](#), Airbnb CEO Brian Chesky shared his thoughts on the company's AI strategy, cautioning investors that AI chatbots can't yet be thought of as the "new Google." That is, AI chatbots, while potentially driving new leads to the travel and services business, aren't entirely a replacement for the referrals that the dominant search engine brings.

At least not at this time.

"I think we're still kind of feeling out the space," the exec told investors on the Q2 earnings call. "The thing I want to caution is I don't think that AI agents — I don't think we should think of chatbots like Google — I don't think we should think of them as the 'new Google' yet."

This, Chesky explained, is because AI models aren't "proprietary."

"We also have to remember that the model powering ChatGPT is not proprietary. It's not exclusive to ChatGPT. We — Airbnb — can also use

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Rebecca Bellan

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the API, and there are other models that we can use,” he said.

Painting a broader picture of the AI landscape, Chesky said that in addition to chatbots and other AI agents, there will be custom-built startups designed for specific applications, as well as other incumbents that have made the shift to AI.

“One of the things we’ve noticed is it’s not enough to just have ... the best model. You have to be able to tune the model and build a custom interface for the right application. And I think that’s the key,” he said.

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The company told investors it will look to take advantage of AI in a number of ways.

Airbnb shared during the call that its AI customer service agent in the U.S. reduced the percentage of guests contacting a human agent by 15%, for instance. This was actually harder than tackling the lower-hanging fruit involving travel planning and

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Inspiration, Chesky said, because AI agents performing customer service can't hallucinate. They have to be accurate and helpful at all times.

Airbnb's customer service agent was built using 13 different models and trained on tens of thousands of conversations, and is currently available in English in the U.S. This year, Airbnb will roll it out to more languages, and next year, it will become more personalized and agentic. That means it would be able to understand if someone reaches out to cancel a reservation; not only would it be able to tell them how to do so, but it could also do it for them. The agent could also help plan and book trips.

Plus, AI will come to Airbnb's search next year, the CEO said.

However, the company has not fully fleshed out its plans for working with third-party AI agents, although it's considering it. Users still need an Airbnb account to make a booking.

Because of this, Chesky doesn't think agentic AI would turn its business into a commodity, the way that booking flights has become. Instead, he sees AI as "potentially interesting lead generation" for the company.

"I think the key thing is going to be for us to lead and become the first place for people to book travel on Airbnb. As far as whether or not we integrate with AI agents, I think that's something that we're certainly open to," he said.

Airbnb beat analysts' expectations in the quarter with revenue of \$3.1 billion and earnings per share of \$1.03, but the stock [dropped](#) on its forecast of slower growth in the second half of the year.

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Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor |

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

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